Gangadasa Pandita

Гангадас Пандит · @gangadasa-pandita

The Teacher of Navadvipa

In the Navadvipa of Mahaprabhu's time he was known as Sri Gangadasa Pandita. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls him now “vipra Gangadasa,” “Gangadasa the brahmana,” now “the crown of teachers” (adhyapaka-shiromani, Adi 8.26; upadhyaya-shiromani, Madhya 1.267): in the whole town there was no greater teacher. Yet his glory for all ages is that the Lord Himself studied under him. Krishnadasa Kaviraja, describing the tree of Sri Chaitanya, says that Gangadasa Pandita is immeasurably dear to the Lord and that the mere remembrance of him can destroy all the fetters of worldly existence (CC, Adi 10.29).

He belongs to those eternal associates of the Lord who came into the world before Him and awaited His descent:

“By the order of Lord Chaitanya many of His eternal associates, such as Sri Chandrashekhara, Jagadisha, Gopinatha Acharya, Shriman Pandita, Murari Gupta, Sri Garuda Pandita and Gangadasa Pandita, were born secretly in Nadia before His coming.” (CB, Adi 2.98–99)[1]

Advaita Acharya, the incarnation of Maha-Vishnu, called Krishna to descend to earth for the deliverance of all, and the Lord desired that those who were to be His elders in His pastimes — the guru-varga — should appear before Him. Gangadasa Pandita is one of them: in the Lord's lila he became His teacher.

Where exactly he was born, the sources do not say quite alike. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” it was Nadia; the translation of the “Charitamrita,” however, says that Nityananda Prabhu, Gangadasa Pandita, Murari Gupta and Mukunda were born in Radha-desha (Adi 13.61)[2].

Even before the Lord's advent, when Advaita Acharya returned to Bengal, the local Vaishnavas — Srivasa, Chandrashekhara, Gangadasa and others — gathered around Him, and He spent most of His time among them. Grieving that the world had forgotten God, Advaita once vowed in anger: “Listen, Shuklambara, Gangadasa, Srivasa! I shall bring Krishna, and everyone shall see it: He Himself will descend and deliver all — together with devotees such as you” (CB, Adi 2.118–119).

Gangadasa lived in Ganganagara, very close to the house of Jagannatha Mishra; so writes Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati too in his commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.” According to tradition, when Bhagiratha was leading the Ganga down to earth, the goddess of the river halted at this spot and waited for Gauranga to appear; hence the name of the quarter, “the town of the Ganga.” Today pilgrims on the parikrama of Navadvipa-dhama sit at a certain spot near the Yogapitha temple and hear there of the glory of Gangadasa's house, although, according to one of the biographies, his house itself in fact stood in Simantadvipa.

A Student without Equal

When Nimai had received the upanayana — Gaurasundara then displayed the pastime of accepting the sacred thread and the lila of a brahmana for the deliverance of souls — and, like Vamana, had gone round to everyone begging alms, He wished to study under Gangadasa Pandita. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says of Gangadasa:

“There lived then in Navadvipa the crown of teachers, Gangadasa Pandita, like unto Sandipani” (CB, Adi 8.26)[3].

Sandipani Muni was Krishna's teacher; so too it fell to Gangadasa, in the Lord's pastime, to become His teacher. Jagannatha Mishra, understanding his son's wish, brought Him to the brahmana's house and said: “I give you my son; teach Him everything,” and Gangadasa joyfully replied that great good fortune had come to him (CB, Adi 8.27–31). The student was so handsome and so virtuous that the teacher could not rejoice enough; he kept Nimai by his side and cared for Him almost as for his own son (CB, Adi 8.32).

It was enough for Nimai to hear His teacher's explanation once to remember it forever: the “Charitamrita” says that in the house of the grammar teacher Gangadasa Pandita He quickly learned all the rules and, having heard any sutra once, could repeat it whenever He liked (Adi 15.5). Among Gangadasa's thousands of students no one could compare with Him in memory or intellect, and the teacher, marvelling at His gifts, held Nimai to be the best of all and greatly rejoiced in it (CB, Adi 8.33–36).

The teacher seated Nimai first among all the students and said: “Study diligently, My boy — you will become a Bhattacharya, I tell you firmly.” “For one whom you bless,” the Lord replied, “is the title of Bhattacharya hard to attain?” (CB, Adi 8.189–192). Thus He Who is Himself the source of all knowledge gave honour to His teacher's blessing.

Every day, having performed sandhya and His other duties at dawn, Nimai came with the other students to Gangadasa's assembly and began to debate: He asked questions, examined the answers, argued and refuted (CB, Adi 10.6–9); at times He refuted all the explanations of the teacher himself — and then at once established them anew (Adi 8.34). His companions — Murari Gupta, Krishnananda, Kamalakanta (CB, Adi 8.37–38) — had the worst of it: Nimai put tricky logical questions to them, and would interpret one and the same sutra first so and then quite differently, and these debates amazed everyone. In the same school — Gangadasa's Sanskrit tol, his pathashala — Mukunda Datta also studied. Nimai baffled not only Mukunda but the senior students too, and even the teacher himself, who only rejoiced that he had so learned a student.

Later books also remember this place. The “Bhakti-ratnakara,” according to one of the biographies, shows it to the pilgrims: “This is the house of Gangadasa Pandita, where the son of Shachi studied grammar”; here He gave His own interpretations of the sutras and playfully tested Murari Gupta, Krishnananda, Kamalakanta and His other classmates with questions[4].

Surrounded by His students, Sarasvati-pati, the husband of the goddess of learning, Gaurachandra walked about Navadvipa, absorbed in the sciences. In the whole town, apart from Gangadasa Pandita, there was no pandita able fully to understand His explanations, and only with him, His teacher, did the Lord discuss the books: Gangadasa is the one “greatly fortunate” man from whom, in the words of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the Lord in His pastime “received learning” (Adi 11.7–8).

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” why the Lord became a student. Gaura-Narayana is the Lord of Vaikuntha, the sole repository of all the shastras, the very embodiment of the wealth of knowledge. Descending into the world, He accepts a form and circumstances resembling human ones and, as Krishna once did with Sandipani, wished to study grammar and other sciences. He Himself had nothing to acquire: studying with Gangadasa, the Lord merely played the role of a student, showing by His own example that a teacher must possess real knowledge, not a show of learning[5].

Lochana Dasa and Murari Gupta speak of the same. The young Lord had three teachers — Vishnu Pandita, Sudarshana and Gangadasa: “Under Sudarshana and the pandit Gangadasa the Teacher of the world studied — for their own good” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 9, v. 707). Murari explains: “He Himself bestowed knowledge on the brahmanas; and under those who were the greatest of panditas He studied — for their own great good” (Murari, 1.9.2). The Lord, appearing by His yogamaya in a human form,

studied to instruct the world and for the good of His teachers (Murari, 1.9.1–3).

After Gaya

In 1509 Nimai returned from Gaya transformed. The Vaishnavas of Navadvipa — Srivasa, Shriman, Gadadhara, Sadashiva, Shuklambara — marvelled at the change and rejoiced that He had left debates for devotion to Krishna and for preaching. Again and again the Lord was absorbed in wondrous states of prema, and on returning to outward consciousness He went first of all to His teacher:

“Partly returning to outward consciousness, Vishvambhara went to the house of Gangadasa Pandita. He bowed at the feet of His teacher, and the teacher at once rose and with great reverence embraced Mahaprabhu.” (CB, Madhya 1.120–121)

Thus the Lord showed how a student ought to honour his teacher, and Gangadasa showed how a guru receives a beloved student: with reverence and with love.

“The teacher said: ‘My dear, how glorious Your life is! You have granted liberation to the families of Your parents.’” (CB, Madhya 1.122)

Study that does not bring one to devotion to Krishna is spent in vain, while devotion frees a person's forebears, paternal and maternal alike — so one of the biographies explains these words. Then Gangadasa spoke of Nimai's students: they all wait for Him alone and without Him do not open their books — nor would they open them even if Brahma himself told them to. “Now You have returned at last,” he concluded. “Go home today, and tomorrow begin the lessons” (CB, Madhya 1.123–124)[6].

The lessons resumed: surrounded by His students, the Lord came to the house of Mukunda-Sanjaya and sat in his chandi-mandapa. But now in every word, in every expression He revealed Krishna, and the students ceased to understand Him. Bewildered, they went to Gangadasa:

“‘In all His explanations Nimai Pandita tells us that Krishna is the only meaning of every word. Since He returned from Gaya, the essence of all His explanations comes down to Krishna.’” (CB, Madhya 1.262–263)

“We do not understand why He acts like this,” they said. “Tell us, what are we to do?” (CB, Madhya 1.266). The students were hearing the highest truth, which they were not yet able to receive. Gangadasa only laughed and promised to speak with Nimai himself that evening (CB, Madhya 1.267–269).

In the afternoon the Lord came and, touching His teacher's feet, sat before him. Gangadasa blessed Him and said:

“‘Dear Vishvambhara! Listen to what I shall tell You. Only the very fortunate become learned brahmanas. Your maternal grandfather is Nilambara Chakravarti, and Your father is Jagannatha Mishra Purandara. In the families of Your father and mother there have never been ignorant men. You too are an eminent scholar and possess the deepest knowledge.’” (CB, Madhya 1.272–274)

And he began to exhort Nimai not to abandon study: “If giving up learning means becoming a devotee, are Your father and grandfather then not devotees? By learning a brahmana becomes a Vaishnava-brahmana: how can an unlettered man tell right from wrong? Chant the name of Krishna — and study. Teach the shastras to Your students as is proper, and put no other meaning into them — I adjure You” (CB, Madhya 1.275–278; retold from the Bengali). The Lord replied:

“‘By the mercy of your feet no one in all Navadvipa can defeat Me in debate.’” (CB, Madhya 1.279)

“I shall teach in the very centre of the town,” He went on, “and we shall see whether anyone has the strength to find a flaw in My explanations” (CB, Madhya 1.280–281). Hearing this, Gangadasa was pleased (CB, Madhya 1.282). This conversation and the teacher's reproaches too are a pastime:

Gangadasa played in it his role of a caring teacher-pandita, and the Lord the role of a scholar delighting in knowledge (vidya-vilasa). There is no worldly pride in His words: He, the source of all knowledge, merely gives honour to His teacher's mercy.

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura himself, having told of this, bows down to Gangadasa:

“I humbly bow at the feet of Gangadasa Pandita, whose student became the Lord of the Vedas Himself, the husband of Sarasvati, the goddess of knowledge. What more could fortunate Gangadasa Pandita desire, whose student is worshipped by the inhabitants of all fourteen worlds?” (CB, Madhya 1.283–284)

A student glorifies his teacher — and Gangadasa is glorified forever by the fact that the Lord was his student. No wonder Srivasa Pandita too, offering a prayer to the Lord, begins it with the words: “I respectfully bow at the lotus feet of the student of Gangadasa Pandita” (CB, Madhya 2.274).

The Ferry

Soon after His return from Gaya, Mahaprabhu displayed the Mahaprakasha in the house of Srivasa: for seven praharas — twenty-one hours — He sat on the throne of Vishnu, openly revealing Himself. Calling one devotee after another to Himself, He blessed each and reminded him of his past. Gangadasa's turn came too. Here is what, according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the Lord said to him (Madhya 9.109–117; our translation, from the Bengali text):

“Do you remember how, in fear of the king, you fled by night with your whole family? You came to the ferry, but there was no boat anywhere, and you were in distress. The night was already ending and still no boat came, and you wept bitterly. You feared that before your eyes the yavanas would touch your household, and you resolved to throw yourself into the Ganga. Then I took a boat and, in the guise of a ferryman, rowed to you along the Ganga. Seeing the boat, you rejoiced and with great love began to beg: ‘Brother, save me this time! My caste, life, wealth, body — all are in your hands. Protect me, take me across with my family — and you shall have a tanka and a pair of cloths as a reward.’ I took you across with your family and then returned to My Vaikuntha.”

No one knew of this except Gangadasa himself. Hearing the Lord's words, he was immersed in an ocean of bliss. “As you were crossing the Ganga, you thought of Me,” Mahaprabhu added. “Do you remember now that it was I who took you across?” — and Gangadasa fell senseless to the ground (CB, Madhya 9.118–120).

The ferryman who rowed at dawn to the despairing brahmana was no chance boatman but the Lord Himself, the eternal Lord of Vaikuntha, Who long before revealing Himself in Navadvipa was protecting His associate. And He alone knows the hidden past of those who belong to Him.

In the Kirtanas of Navadvipa

Gangadasa was among those who surrounded the Lord in the years of kirtana. Nityananda Prabhu, wandering about Navadvipa in a childlike mood and playing with the boys, would sometimes go visiting Gangadasa or Murari (CB, Madhya 8.25); once, according to one of the biographies, He called on Gangadasa right after He had been worshipped in the house of Srivasa. And at night Mahaprabhu held kirtana in the house of Srivasa and sometimes at Chandrashekhara's, and among the few intimate associates admitted to these kirtanas the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” names Nityananda, Gadadhara, Advaita, Srivasa, Vidyanidhi, Murari, Hiranya, Haridasa — and Gangadasa (Madhya 8.112–116). Mahaprabhu Himself also called at Gangadasa's house (Madhya 8.84), and the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” opens one of its chapters with the words: “Glory to the Lord of Gangadasa and Vasudeva!” (Madhya 21.2).

When Nityananda and Haridasa, escaping from Jagai and Madhai, came to the Lord and told Him about them, Mahaprabhu asked who these two were:

“Gangadasa and Srivasa, who were sitting before the Lord, told of the misdeeds of these drunkards: ‘O Lord, their names are Jagai and Madhai. They are the sons of a pious brahmana and were born here. Bad company has corrupted them.’” (CB, Madhya 13.121–123)

So from the lips of Gangadasa and Srivasa the Lord heard of those whom He was soon to deliver. And when He had saved them, granted them the right to sing the holy names and sat with His most intimate associates behind closed doors, Gangadasa was among the few who were present there:

“Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Haridasa Thakura, Garuda, Ramai, Shrinivasa, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara Pandita and Chandrashekhara Acharya were well acquainted with the pastimes of Lord Chaitanya.” (CB, Madhya 13.239–240)

He was there too when Mahaprabhu went with the devotees and with Jagai and Madhai to the Ganga and played in its waters (CB, Madhya 13.336–339).

In the house of Chandrashekhara, where the Lord enacted the pastimes of Vraja, Gangadasa also had his part. When Brahmananda came on stage with Gadadhara in the guise of the old companion Suprabha, the devotees began to question the travellers, and Gangadasa asked: “Where will you stay tonight?” — “You will give us a place,” Brahmananda replied. “You ask too much,” Gangadasa retorted. “Go somewhere else” (CB, Madhya 18.102–108). Kavi Karnapura in the drama “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” adds that for this performance, to which only the worthy were to be admitted, Srivasa at the Lord's word “appointed as gatekeeper the best of brahmanas, named Gangadasa, the most trusted man of the Lord” (Act 3).

On the day when the procession of nagara-sankirtana moved to the house of Chand Kazi and subdued him, “Gangadasa the brahmana” walked with the Lord (CB, Madhya 23.150). And when the procession reached the house of Shridhara, the Lord's associates saw how much love He showed His devotee and wept with joy:

“Haridasa, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara, Murari, Mukunda and Sri Chandrashekhara began to weep.” (CB, Madhya 23.450)

And when the Lord resolved to take sannyasa, the grief of the Vaishnavas knew no bounds:

“Falling to the ground in the Lord's courtyard, Mukunda, Murari, Shridhara, Gadadhara, Gangadasa, Srivasa and his family, Chandrashekhara and Haridasa wept without cease.” (CB, Madhya 28.85)

That last night of the Lord in Navadvipa the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” shows through the eyes of Gangadasa. Hearing that Advaita had come from Shantipura, he goes to Srivasa's house and sees the kirtana: Vakreshvara dances, Vishvambhara Himself, Advaita, Nityananda. Towards the end of the night, dozing off, he calls out in his sleep: “O Lord Vishvambhara, where are You?” — and at dawn Shachi's messengers are already going about Navadvipa and ask him too whether the Lord is with him. When it became clear that the Lord had gone, Srivasa entrusted Gangadasa with the hardest task — to preserve the life of the Lord's mother: she trusts his words. Gangadasa brought the devotees her question whether her son was well, and then her answer: “What are you hiding? He has only gone the way of his elder brother” (Act 4, v. 38) — the way of Vishvarupa, who too had taken sannyasa.

Shantipura and Puri

Having taken sannyasa, the Lord came to Shantipura, to the house of Advaita Acharya, and the devotees of Navadvipa hastened there to Him, Gangadasa among them[7]. The “Charitamrita” names him among those who were there with the Lord:

“Srivasa, Ramai, Vidyanidhi, Gadadhara, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara, Murari and Shuklambara were there.” (CC, Madhya 3.153)

When the Lord settled in Puri, Gangadasa was among the earliest devotees from Bengal who set out to see Him there, and afterwards he went to Nilachala for the Ratha-yatra. On that first arrival of the Bengalis the Lord was not in Puri: after the Snana-yatra Jagannatha is hidden from view (anavasara), and Mahaprabhu, unable to bear the separation, had gone away to Alalanatha; but on learning that the devotees from Gauda had come, He returned at once. King Prataparudra and Sarvabhauma watched the arriving Vaishnavas from the palace roof, and Sarvabhauma named each one to the king:

“And this is Acharyaratna, Purandara Pandita, Gangadasa Pandita and Shankara Pandita.” (CC, Madhya 11.85)

The Lord came out to meet His devotees and, before the eyes of the people of Puri, honoured each one:

“Thus Sri Chaitanya embraced and respectfully glorified all His devotees, such as Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi, Pandita Gadadhara, Gangadasa, Hari Bhatta and Acharya Purandara.” (CC, Madhya 11.159–160)

At the Ratha-yatra Mahaprabhu divided the devotees into seven kirtana groups:

“Advaita Acharya was appointed the dancer of the first group. Then the Lord formed the second group, in which the lead singer was Srivasa.” (CC, Madhya 13.38)

To sing the responses to Srivasa, according to the “Charitamrita,” were Gangadasa, Haridasa, Shriman, Shubhananda and Sri Rama Pandita, and the dancer of this group was Sri Nityananda (Madhya 13.39)[8]. In each of the seven groups the Lord appeared now in one form, now in many at once; He Himself danced and sang and drew the devotees into the dance — and was so absorbed in this bliss that He paid no heed at all to His own nature[9].

Year after year Gangadasa came from Gauda to Puri together with the other Vaishnavas; the “Charitamrita,” listing those who went there in one of these years, names him too:

“Together with everyone there also went Vasudeva Datta, Murari Gupta, Gangadasa, Shrimana Sena, Shriman Pandita, Akinchana Krishnadasa, Murari, Garuda Pandita, Buddhimanta Khan, Sanjaya Purushottama, Bhagavan Pandita, Shuklambara Brahmachari and Nrisimhananda Brahmachari.” (CC, Antya 10.9–11)

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says the same: when the time of the Ratha-yatra drew near, “joyfully set out the pandit Gangadasa, the remembrance of whom destroys the bonds of karma” (Antya 8.9), and Murari Gupta calls him “the pandita named Gangadasa, endowed with every good quality” (Murari, 4.17.4). In Puri, at Lake Narendra, together with Srivasa, Shrirama, Haridasa, Vakreshvara, Gopinatha and Chandrashekhara, absorbed in the Lord's pastimes, he splashed water on his companions, and they on him (CB, Antya 8.125–126).

In 1514, returning from Ramakeli, the Lord again stayed at Shantipura with Advaita, and Advaita sent a palanquin to Navadvipa for Shachi-mata. Her joy at the news “Gaurasundara is in Shantipura” cannot be described (CB, Antya 4.233–235), and it fell to Gangadasa to escort her there:

“Gangadasa Pandita, the dear associate of the Lord, immediately set out on the way together with Shachi-mata.” (CB, Antya 4.237)

Murari Gupta and other devotees went with them (CB, Antya 4.238).

When and where Gangadasa Pandita left this world, the sources do not say. Neither the day of his appearance nor the day of his departure is given by any biography; nor are they found in our calendar.

In the Pastimes of Rama and Krishna

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who Gangadasa was before:

“The sage Vasishtha, once the guru of Raghunatha, became by a special manifestation Gangadasa and Sudarshana.” (GGD 53)

So the guru of Ramachandra became a teacher once again in the pastimes of Lord Gaura: Sudarshana Pandita too taught the young Nimai. The biographies speak of this verse differently: one calls Gangadasa a special manifestation (prakasha-vigraha) of Vasishtha and does not mention Sudarshana, another names both. Lochana Dasa and Murari Gupta, too, name Sudarshana and Gangadasa side by side as teachers of the young Lord (CM, Adi-khanda, part 9, v. 707; Murari, 1.9.1).

With Krishna's teacher, however, the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” only compares him: “Gangadasa Pandita, like unto Sandipani.” Sandipani himself, according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” became in the Lord's pastimes Keshava Bharati, who gave Him sannyasa:

“The sage Sandipani, who once in Mathura gave Krishna the sacred thread, has now become Keshava Bharati.” (GGD 52)

One of the biographies, following the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” reconciles the two comparisons: Vasishtha, the guru of Ramachandra, entered into Sandipani in Krishna-lila, and so Gangadasa-Vasishtha is connected with Sandipani as well. This is the opinion of the compiler of that dictionary; the primary sources say of Gangadasa only “like unto Sandipani.”

Elsewhere Karnapura writes:

“Acharya Sri Jagannatha and Gangadasa, dear to the Lord, were formerly Durvasa, dear to the gopis in Nidhuvana.” (GGD 111)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta too cites this same verse about Gangadasa in his commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 2.99)[10].

Significance

The sources draw the life of Gangadasa Pandita in a few strokes, but each of them is bound up with the Lord. An eternal associate who descended before Him in the role of an elder, he became the teacher of the One Who is Himself the source of all knowledge, and took Him into his home almost as a son. The Lord, playing the role of a student, taught by this example both students and teachers: a teacher must possess real knowledge, a student must honour his teacher, and knowledge that does not bring one to devotion to Krishna bears no fruit.

In the Mahaprakasha the Lord revealed that long before He had protected him at the night ferry — and this shows that He guards His associates always and alone knows their hidden past. From then on Gangadasa remained beside the Lord to the end: in the kirtanas of Navadvipa, at the deliverance of Jagai and Madhai, in Shantipura, in Puri and at the Ratha-yatra. The biographies of the Lord's associates invariably name him in their lists, and Vrindavana Dasa Thakura bows to him as to the one whose student became the Lord of the Vedas: what more could a teacher desire, whose student is worshipped by the fourteen worlds?

1. In one place one of the biographies refers here to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” Adi 9.98–99; read Adi 2.98–99.

2. The Bengali line of the “Charitamrita” allows another reading as well: Nityananda appeared in Radha-desha, while Gangadasa, Murari and Mukunda appeared elsewhere; so one of the biographies understands it. This agrees with the words of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” that Gangadasa was born in Nadia.

3. The biographies often take this verse to mean that Gangadasa is Sandipani Muni himself. The verse itself, however, says “like unto Sandipani” (*ye-hena sāndīpani*); on whom Sandipani became in the Lord's pastimes, see below, in the section

“In the Pastimes of Rama and Krishna.”

4. The verse numbers (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 12.2185–2188) are given after this biography; our translation of that book does not yet exist, and the verses have not been checked.

5. The conclusion about teachers is drawn by one of the biographies, retelling Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 8.24). In the commentary as given in our edition, the thought of Gaura-Narayana studying as Krishna did with Sandipani is the same, but the conclusion drawn from it is that no one can do without a guru.

6. The biographies render Gangadasa's words about the students differently: according to one, he said that since Nimai had left none of His students had opened a book, and told Him to begin the lessons from the next day; according to another, he told Him that neither He nor His students should open their books that day, “even if Brahma himself should bid it.” The text follows the Bengali original.

7. One of the biographies writes that “after the sannyasa” Gangadasa brought Shachi-mata to Shantipura. This account is taken from the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4.233–239), and there it concerns another visit of the Lord to Shantipura — in 1514 (see below). In 1510, according to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 3.137), Shachi was brought to Shantipura in a palanquin by Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna.

8. Which Haridasa sang in this group the biographies understand differently: one, with a question mark, Bada (the Elder) Haridasa, another Haridasa Thakura; the “Charitamrita” says simply “Haridasa.”

9. This is not forgetfulness under the sway of maya: the Lord is the master of maya. Absorbed in the bliss of kirtana in the mood of His own devotee (bhakta-bhava), He Himself allowed this bliss to engulf Him entirely.

10. One of the biographies numbers this verse 199 and calls the place “Madhuvana”; in our translation it is verse 111 and “Nidhuvana.” Another reading is also possible: the words “ganga-dasa” here may be an epithet of Jagannatha Acharya (“servant of the Ganga”), since Karnapura has already spoken of Gangadasa in verse 53.